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From Romantic Knowledge to Occultist Programs

I. The Era of *Naturphilosophie* and the Great Syntheses

1. Nature Philosophy in the Romantic Era (1790–1847)

In the last decade of the eighteenth century, a new manner of approaching the study of Nature emerged, which lasted about fifty years and barely reappeared thereafter. This is *Naturphilosophie*, which is especially part of German romanticism in the broad sense. In several of its representatives, it takes an aspect that pairs it directly with the theosophical current. In its most general form, it is, as Friedrich W. J. von Schelling describes it, an attempt to bring to light that which Christianity had always repressed—namely, Nature. Three factors contributed to this dawning.

First is the persistence of the idea of *magia* among chemist-physicists such as Oetinger ([chapter 3](#), section I, 2). The second factor is the influence exerted by certain philosophers: French naturalism (Georges-Louis de Buffon, Jean Le Rond d'Alembert), not lacking in speculations on the life of matter; Immanuel Kant, who appeared to see in the universe a product of the imagination, of the synthesizing and spontaneous activity of the mind; Baruch Spinoza, in whom people believed they then discovered that Nature is something spiritual and that the whole of the finite world proceeds from a Spirit, a focus of energy. The third factor is the atmosphere proper to the preromantic period, which has a taste for animal magnetism, galvanism, electricity (experiments of Galvani in 1789, Volta battery in 1800), and which sees the publication of bold syntheses developed by great *Kulturphilosophen* such as Johann Gottfried Herder. Now, three fundamental tenets seem to characterize *Naturphilosophie*:

1. The “identity” of *Spirit and Nature*, considered as the two seeds of a single common root. Nature rests on a spiritual principle: a Spirit inhabits it, speaks through it (a *natura naturans* is hidden behind the *natura naturata*), and she has a history: She is, like the Spirit, engaged in a process of a highly dramatic character.

2. Nature is a living net of correspondences to be deciphered and integrated into a holistic worldview. It is full of symbolic implications and its true meaning escapes merely empirical examination. Consequently, rigorous experimentation is never more than a necessary first step towards a comprehensive, holistic knowledge of both visible and invisible processes.

3. *Naturphilosophie* is by definition multidisciplinary. Its representatives are all more or less specialists (chemists, physicists, physicians, geologists, and engineers), but their thinking extends to eclectic syntheses striving to encompass, in its complexity, a polymorphous universe made of different degrees of reality. The compartmentalization of Nature into strictly distinct subjects here gives way to the attempt to grasp a Whole animated by dynamic polarities.

These three characteristics imply that the knowledge of Nature and the knowledge of oneself must go together, that a scientific fact must be perceived as a sign, that the signs correspond with one another, and that concepts borrowed from chemistry are transposable to astronomy or to human feelings. Little wonder that animal magnetism (cf. *infra*, section I, 3) is, in this philosophical current, a subject of avid interest.

The major contribution of *Naturphilosophie* to the science of the nineteenth century was the discovery of the unconscious—by the works, notably, of Gotthilf Heinrich von Schubert (*Die Symbolik des Traums*, 1814). In this very romanticism, in fact, psychoanalysis has deep roots, which began to develop with Eduard von Hartmann (*Philosophie des Unbewussten*, 1869). In this context, too, modern homeopathy came to birth with Samuel Hahnemann. Furthermore, it is not surprising that Christian theosophy, because of its own characteristics ([chapter 2](#), section II, 2), could have inspired many *Naturphilosophen*. Moreover, the foundation myth underpinning a number of their discourses is that of the “Redeemed Redeemer”—in other words, the theosophico-romantic narrative of a captured Light, captive but capable of being awakened (“redeemed”) by another Light that had remained free. Hence the frequent use of the two terms “light” and “gravity” (*Licht* and *Schwere*) in such discourses—“gravity” rather than “darkness—the latter understood as something by which the primitive energies had originally been engulfed, but from which they tend to re-emerge. Here, the relationship with alchemy is obvious. As the historian of philosophy Jean-Louis Vieillard-Baron recently mentioned, *Naturphilosophie* is “the redemption of Nature through the thought of humankind, who alone reintegrates her into the absolute.”

2. Main Representatives of This Current

The Catholic Franz von Baader (1765–1841), physician, mining engineer, and professor of philosophy at the University of Munich, greatly contributed to the emergence of *Naturphilosophie* in the Germanic countries. Let us mention in this regard especially his two essays, *Beiträge zur Elementarphysiologie* (1797) and *Ueber das pythagoräische Quadrat in der Natur* (1798). At the same time, Friedrich W. J. Schelling (1775–1854) and Carl August von Eschenmayer (1758–1862; section I, 3) also added to this impetus, the first with *Von der Weltseele* (1798), and the second with *Sätze aus der Naturmetaphysik* (1797).

In the history of philosophy, Baader occupies a position rich in fertile tensions between Schelling and Georg W. F. Hegel (1770–1831), as distant from the “naturalism” of the former as from the “idealism” of the latter. Above all, he is the most important Christian theosopher of the nineteenth century. This *Böhmius redivivus*, as he has been called, takes his place among the great hermeneuts of the thought of Boehme and of Saint-Martin, while simultaneously marking Christian theosophy with his own thought. He picks up the principal themes dear to the two latter (such as the Sophia, the ontological androgeneity of humanity, celestial objects, the successive falls, love, etc.) and reinterprets them in an original fashion while integrating the science of his time with them—notably speculations about animal magnetism. Although lacking the prophetic voice so characteristic of the theosophers of the baroque period (and still echoing in Saint-Martin), Baader's philosophical language is nonetheless strewn with dazzling insights (cf. e.g., one of his most inspired works: the *Fermenta cognitionis*, 1822–1825; French translation published in 1985). Additionally, Baader was with Julie de Krüdener one of the direct inspirers of the original project of the Holy Alliance, in the period when Tsar Alexander I was leaning toward certain forms of mysticism, and his voice long made itself heard in the liberal Catholic milieux of Europe. Let us mention (in alphabetical order) some of the other *Naturphilosophen* whose thought is more or less characterized by theosophy or, at least, by an orientation of a pansophic type:

Joseph Ennemoser (1787–1854; *Der Magnetismus in Verhältnis zur Natur und Religion*, 1842); Joseph von Görres (1776–1848; *Aphorismen*, 1802; section I, 4; section II, 1); Justinus Kerner (1786–1852; *Eine Erscheinung aus dem Nachtgebiete der Natur*, 1836); Johann Friedrich von Meyer (1772–1849; cf. especially his articles published in *Blätter für höhere Wahrheit*, 1818–1832); Novalis (pseudonym of Friedrich von Hardenberg, 1772–1801; *Das Allgemeine Brouillon* 1798–1799); Hans Christian Oersted (1777–1851; *Der Geist der Natur*, 1850–1851); Gotthilf Heinrich von Schubert (1780–1860; *Ansichten über die Nachtseite der Naturwissenschaft*, 1808); Johann Wilhelm Ritter (1776–1810; *Fragmente aus dem Nachlass eines jungen Physikers*, 1810); Henrik Steffens (1773–1845; *Grundzüge der*

philosophischen Naturwissenschaften, 1806); Ignaz Troxler (1780–1866; *Über das Leben und sein Problem*, 1806); and Johann Jakob Wagner (1766–1834; *Organon der menschlichen Erkenntnis*, 1830). Gustav Theodor Fechner (1801–1887; *Zend Avesta*, 1851; section I, 4) and Carl Gustav Carus (1789–1869; *Psyche*, 1848; *Natur und Idee*, 1862) are situated in the extension of this movement that was already on the wane. Let us note that Johann Wolfgang von Goethe (1749–1832) has no real connection with it, with the possible exception of some of his scientific works, like *Über die Spiraltendenz* (1831), and his essays on the metamorphosis of plants and on colors (*Zur Farbenlehre*, 1810).

Notwithstanding, this movement is not limited to the Germanic world. Part of the work of Saint-Martin ([chapter 3](#), section I, 2) can be related to it; especially, his work *De l'Esprit des choses*, 1802); and for the English domain we could cite William Paley (1743–1805; *Natural Theology*, 1892), as well as Sir Humphrey Davy (1778–1829; *Consolations in Travel*, 1830).

3. *Naturphilosophie* and Animal Magnetism

One of the many publications by Justinus Kerner about animal magnetism is his famous work *Die Seherin von Prevorst* (1829, translated as *The Seeress of Prevorst*, 1855). This is an account of the visions of a young woman, Friederike Hauffe, whom he had magnetized over the course of several months. During her trances, she had held conversations about the worlds of the beyond, to which this state gave her access. Carl August von Eschenmayer, co-founder of the journal *Archiv für den thierischen Magnetismus* (1817–1826; section I, 2), commented on the visions of this woman and of others similarly magnetized. He is the author, among several works and essays relevant to this area, of *Mysterien des inneren Lebens* (1830), one of the most interesting publications of the period on the faculties of clairvoyance induced by animal magnetism.

Eschenmayer, Kerner, and many others (including Baader) held that magnetic ecstasy enables the subject to recover for a few moments the state that was ours before the original fall. They also believed that they could rediscover in the descriptions of journeys made through the celestial spheres (the “imaginal world,” to employ the expression dear to Henry Corbin [[chapter 5](#); section I, 2]) many elements of a nature to confirm the authenticity of the visions. Seventeenth-century theosophers such as Boehme, Gichtel, Lead, or Pordage ([chapter 2](#), section II, 2), for example, had been graced with similar visions without resorting to animal magnetism (which had not yet been discovered, anyhow).

In France, Marie-Thérèse Mathieu, magnetized by G. P. Billot in the 1820s, entered into contact with her guardian angel. In his book *Arcanes de la vie future dévoilée* (1848–1860, three volumes [*The Celestial Telegraph. Or, Secrets of the Life to Come*, 1851]), the magnetizer Louis-Alphonse Cahagnet (1805–1885) relates the descriptions that his subjects Bruno Binet and Adèle Maginot gave of the celestial

spaces through which they traveled. The most famous case in the United States is that of Andrew Jackson Davis (1826–1810), who, magnetized for the first time in 1843 (in New York state), was immediately gratified with visions and revelations obtained in the course of his rambles in other worlds, and of which he later gave a detailed narrative in *The Magic Staff* (1857). This book, along with his first work, *The Principles of Nature: Her Divine Revelations* (1847), greatly contributed to his fame. Animal magnetism was obviously not reserved for the *Naturphilosophen* alone, but was a set of practices and discourses widely disseminated in the Western world during this period. It thus entered into the common stock of ideas from which many took their religious bearings on life.

4. Esotericism on the Edge of *Naturphilosophie* (1815–1857)

In the Germany of this period appeared translations of books by Saint-Martin (G. H. von Schubert [*supra*, 3] is the author of one of them). The theosopher from Frankfurt Johann Friedrich von Meyer (*supra*, 3), of subtle and varied works, the first translator into German of the *Sepher Yetzirah* ([chapter 1](#), section III, 1) and especially the author of a new German translation of the Bible, touched on almost all the sciences known as “occult.” His review *Blätter für höhere Wahrheit* (“Pages for a Higher Truth,” 1818–1832; *supra*, section III, 1), of which he was the main contributor, constitutes in this aspect one of the most interesting documents of the period. Again in Germany, three works appeared that sketched a history of “magic”: *Geschichte der Magie* (1822), by Joseph Ennemoser, *Zauberbibliothek* (1821–1826) by Georg Konrad Horst, and the last part of *Christliche Mystik* (1836–1842) by Joseph Görres (section I, 2; section II, 1).

In France, Antoine Fabre d'Olivet ([chapter 3](#), section I, 3) pursued his pagan-oriented work; his *Histoire philosophique du genre humain* (1822–1824), a vast fresco with an ambitious purpose, would be highly prized by the “occultists” of the end of the century. The book of Ferdinand Davis, *Tableau des sciences occultes* (1830), and the first writings of Cahagnet (section I, 3), are already a prefiguration of what would become the occultist current with Éliphas Lévi (section II, 2). After *Philosophie de l'infini* (1814) and *Messianisme* (1831–1839) of the Pole Hoëné-Wronski (section II, 2), there was no dearth of researchers of universal keys, such as Giovanni Malfatti di Montereccio's *Studien über Anarchie und Hierarchie des Wissens* 1845). Simultaneously conservative and close to socialist utopias, Pierre-Simon Ballanche, influenced by the Illuminist current, occupies a respectable place in the landscape of the political philosophy of his period (*Essais de palingénésie sociale*, 1827; *La Vision d'Hébal*, 1831). The abbot Paul François Gaspard Lacuria, author of *Harmonies de l'Être exprimées par les nombres* (1847), found in theosophy the key to music and arithmology. Hortensius Flamel (who is perhaps Éliphas Lévi), author of a *Livre d'or* and a *Livre rouge* (1842), attempted to combine Fourierism and Hermetism.

One of the representatives of swedenborgian theosophy was Jean-Jacques Bernard who, in his work *Opuscules théosophiques* (1822), attempted to reconcile the theosophies of Saint-Martin and of Swedenborg. Edouard Richer and, especially, Jacques F. E. Le Boys des Guays actively propagated the teachings of the same Swedenborg. A messianism introduced in France by the Poles Adam Mickiewicz and André Towianki in the 1840s would greatly influence Éliphas Lévi (section II, 2), just as Hoëné-Wronski would do directly (cf. *supra*). Let us note finally that, in the course of this period extending to 1847, alchemical production seems moribund despite—at least, for France—a *Hermès dévoilé* (1832) by Cyliani (a little book that was to enjoy a lasting success), and a *Cours de philosophie hermétique* (1843) signed by Cambriel.

Ambiguous relationships were cultivated between the esoteric currents and the most picturesque of the socialist utopias, perceptible in Alphonse Esquiros (*De la Vie future du point de vue socialiste*, 1850) or in Jean Reynaud's Druidism (*Terre et Ciel*, 1854). These relationships clearly intertwined in Charles Fourier, the “Ariosto of the utopians,” not so much by the content as by the style of the discourse (see his *Théorie des quatre mouvements*, 1807) His descriptions occasionally bear some resemblance to certain visionary narratives of Swedenborg, of which they sometimes seem an involuntary parody. After 1848, even more than hitherto, Swedenborgianism was tinged by humanitarian prophesy, as in the illuminated socialism of a Louis Lucas (*Une Révolution dans la musique*, 1849), of a Jean-Marie Ragon de Bettignies (*Orthodoxie maçonnique* and *Maçonnerie occulte*, 1853) or of a Henri Delaage (*Le Monde occulte*, 1851). Also marking these years, two substantial essays on alchemy would remain great classics in the eyes of many adepts of this “traditional science”: *A Suggestive Enquiry into the Hermetic Mystery* (1850), by Mary Ann Atwood; and *Alchemy and the Alchemists* (1857), by Ethan Allen Hitchcock. These years were marked, finally, by the fine book of Frédéric Portal, *Les Couleurs symboliques* (1857), the *Zend-Avesta* (1851) of Gustav Theodor Fechner (section I, 2) and the first great anthology of texts of Christian theosophy (*Stimmen aus dem Heiligthum der christlichen Theosophie*, 1851), collected and edited by Julius Hamberger, a close disciple of Baader.

5. Esotericism in Art (1815–1847)

In the seventeenth century, a natural symbiosis occurred between the baroque *imaginaire* and theosophical literature. The same was true of the latter and romanticism, although this relationship is more evident in Germanic countries than elsewhere. If we grant that the synthetic spirit (the taste for global approaches) and the suffering related to the limited human condition comprise the two major characteristics of European romanticism (and of many forms of *gnosis*), then we better understand that the theosophical discourses related to the myth of the fall and the reintegration could find a hearing

among many romantics. Some historians (like Léon Cellier) could even claim, and rightly so, that this myth largely subtends most literary and philosophical productions of that movement.

In France, a certain number of authors, and not the least of them, continued to respond to public taste for these great themes that Illuminism had developed. Thus, regarding novels, Honoré de Balzac was open to inspiration from Saint-Martin and Swedenborg (*Louis Lambert*, 1832; *Séraphita* and *Le Livre mystique*, 1835). A similar inspiration runs through *Consuelo* (1845) by George Sand. The purpose is more didactic and explicit in *Le Magicien* (1836) by Alphonse Esquiros, or in England *Zanoni* (1842) by Sir Edward G. Bulwer-Lytton (section II, 2). This Rosicrucian novel has continued, until today, to inspire many dreams and exegeses of all sorts.

This period also saw Goethe, shortly before his demise in 1832, give his *Faust* the final touches.

Theosophy tinges, sometimes deeply, the *Carnets (Notebooks)* of Joseph Joubert, kept assiduously from 1786 to his death in 1824. The posthumous writings of the painter Philipp Otto Runge ([chapter 3](#), section III, 3), published in 1840–1841, are saturated with thoughts of a theosophical type bearing on art. Of course, magnetism is the subject of many literary adaptations, like *Der Magnetiseur* (1817), by Ernst T. A. Hoffmann, *Mesmeric Revelation* (1844) and *The Facts in the Case of Mr. Valdemar* (1845), by Edgar Allen Poe—all works heralding a genre of writing (the classic “fantastic” literature”) that would flourish starting in the middle of the century.

II. Universal Tradition and Occultism

1. From the Romantic East to the India of the Theosophical Society

At the end of the eighteenth century, images of India had begun deeply to penetrate the Western *imaginaire*. However, the East was especially a discovery of romanticism; compare, for example, the writings of Joseph Görres (section I, 2, 4) on Asian myths (*Mythengeschichte des asiatischen Welt*, 1810) and of Friedrich Schlegel on India (*Ueber die Sprache und Weisheit der Inder*, 1808). These publications, like the general interest in the fairy tales (*Kinder- und Hausmärchen*, 1812–1815, published by Jacob and Wilhelm Grimm), myths, and legends of Europe, belong to the romantic quest for the One. This quest would contribute to revive the idea of *philosophia perennis*, progressively spread to all the traditions of the world, no longer limited to those of the Mediterranean universe, as was still the case in the Renaissance ([chapter 2](#), section I, 1).

The word “Tradition” appears in the German title of a book that would stand out in history, that of Franz Joseph Molitor on Kabbalah (*Philosophie der Geschichte oder über die Tradition*, 1827), followed by *La Kabbale* of Adolphe Franck (1843). In another scholarly work (Jacques Matter, *Histoire du*

gnosticisme, 1828) appears the first use found hitherto of the substantive “esotericism” (cf. *supra*, beginning of the introduction). To this, we may add two obsessive themes: that of the mysteries of the Great Pyramid (John Taylor, *The Great Pyramid*, 1858) and that of Druidism interpreted as the mother religion of humanity. The speculations on the Great Pyramid understandably went together with something like a return of the Hermetist current. For example, in the collection *Das Kloster*, which he directed in Stuttgart from 1849 to 1860, Johann Scheible put into circulation, alongside works by Agrippa and many treatises on magic, a German translation of the *Corpus Hermeticum* (CH; according to the 1706 edition; [chapter 3](#), section I, 1). In 1866, Louis Ménéard published *Hermès Trismégiste* (his translation of major texts of the CH, preceded by an introduction). The book would stimulate new translations and glosses (section II, 3), mostly works by personalities connected with the Theosophical Society or with neo-Rosicrucian Orders.

Founded in 1875, the Theosophical Society (TS) favored the success of this idea of a “universal Tradition” that, at the beginning of the twentieth century, would be labeled “primordial”—the better to define it as the mother of all the others ([chapter 5](#), section II, 1). Helena Petrovna Blavatsky (1831–1991; section III, 2), the principal founder ([chapter 4](#), section II, 2) of the TS, contributed much to it herself through her own works, destined for a lasting success (*Isis Unveiled*, 1877; *The Secret Doctrine*, 1888). Edouard Schuré defended the existence of a Primordial Tradition in his book *Les Grands Initiés* (1889), a bestseller often translated and republished. In it we find again (as in the Renaissance, [chapter 2](#), section 1, 1) a list—a chain—of ancient “Sages” of the *philosophia perennis*, but now flanked with other more exotic names (his list is composed of Rama, Krishna, Hermes, Moses, Orpheus, Pythagoras, Plato, and Jesus). At the end of the century, the emergence of a science of comparative religions and the assembly of a great Parliament of Religions in Chicago (1893) contributed to the dissemination of the expression “Primordial Tradition.”

2. Advent of Spiritualism and Occultism (1847–1860)

During the first half of the century, animal magnetism had met (section I, 3) with wonderful success, one of the original forms that it had taken being narratives, by “magnetized” subjects, bearing on questions about the supernatural world. Now, in 1848, in the United States (one year after the publication of the book by Andrew Jackson Davis quoted *supra*, section I, 3), the spiritualist movement emerged. The sisters Margaretta and Catherine Fox, in Hydesville, New York, heard a mysterious repeated knocking in the house on the night of March 31, 1848. Thinking it might be a message of some sort, they worked out a code that might enable them to respond and ask questions of their own. The belief that the knocking entity was the spirit of a deceased person soon followed. Thus, a new practice of communication with

spirits had come to birth, called Spiritualism, which quickly spread through the United States and then through the rest of the Western world. As we have seen, in the preceding decades, the subjects of animal magnetism entered into relationship with entities—not only with non-human, but also with deceased people. However, in Spiritualism it is essentially with the latter that spiritualists would henceforth try to establish rapport.

Spiritualism does not pertain directly to the history of esoteric currents properly speaking, but it has connections with them by the influence that it exerted everywhere and by the problems that it posed to esotericists of all kinds. Its blossoming and the quasi-simultaneous appearance of the literary genre known as the “fantastic,” in its classical form (section I, 5), coincide with the triumph of the industrial revolution (Karl Marx's *Manifesto* dates from 1847), which is not by happenstance. One of the first outstanding theoreticians of Spiritualism in the United States was Andrew Jackson Davis (cf. *supra*), who first looked askance at this new trend but eventually became won over to it. In France Denizard Hyppolyte Léon Rivail (*alias* Allen Kardec, 1804–1869, *Le Monde des esprits*, 1857) aimed to make Spiritualism into a “religion” tinged with sentimentalism and rationalism. Kardec elevated to the rank of an actual dogma the idea of reincarnation. Less frequently adopted by the English-speaking spiritualists of that time, this idea harmonized well with the egalitarian, socialist, and utopian tendencies of the era (section I, 4).

It was also in the mid-nineteenth century that Occultism (in the sense of “the occultist current”) emerged. One of its first outstanding representatives was a man whose youth had been dedicated to utopian and humanitarian ideas (he was even sentenced as a revolutionary)—namely, Alphonse-Louis Constant (*alias* Éliphas Lévi, 1810–1875). He may have been influenced by Hoëné Wronski (section I, 4), whom he met in 1852. Keenly interested in practical magic and theurgy, he would have evoked the spirit of Apollonius of Tyana in 1854. An unmethodical compiler but a gifted synthesizer, this magus inspired conviction and his appearance was timely. His works *Dogme et ritual de la Haute magie* (1854–1856), *Histoire de la magie* (1860), and *La Clef des Grands Mystères* (1861)—to cite only a few of them—would mark the whole occultist current. The year 1860, moreover, saw the publication, at the same time as his *Histoire de la magie*, of two other works (not “esoterically” committed): *Histoire du merveilleux* by Louis Figuier, and *La Magie et l'astrologie* by Alfred Maury.

3. Growth of Occultism in the Era of Scienticism and Continuity of Theosophy (1860–1914)

The rise of scienticism (the claim that science is the only means of knowledge and that there is no other reality than that based on ordinary perception) was eroding faith in spiritual matters. Facing it was the occultist current (Occultism), an extension of what had begun to be known shortly before as the “occult

sciences” (cf. Ferdinand Denis, section I, 4). This current appeared as an alternative solution—or, rather, as a new response *from* modernity confronted *with* itself, more than as a response *to* modernity proper (cf. introduction, section II, last paragraph). In fact, the occultists were not opposed to modernity and did not consider scientific progress as noxious; they sought instead to integrate them into a global vision capable of bringing out the vacuity of materialism. We recognize here something resembling an echo of the program of the *Naturphilosophen*. However, the occultists are distinguished from them by a more marked taste for “pragmatic evidence” (“scientific proofs”) related to the reality of certain “phenomena” appearing to prove the existence of several orders of reality, and often for various forms of practical “magic”—in a world that seemed definitively disenchanted. Occultism is linked by affinity to the symbolist current in literature and in the arts (section III, 1), just as *Naturphilosophie* was to romanticism.

After Éliphas Lévi (section II, 2), a few strong personalities dominate a rather disparate crowd. In France, Gérard Encausse (*alias* Papus; 1865–1915; section III, 1), a physician, nicknamed “the Balzac of Occultism” (his work is prolific), is considered still today by a great many admirers as a magus, a true “initiate.” His *Traité de science occulte* appeared in 1888, as did the first number of his periodical *L'Initiation*. The Society for Psychical Research was founded in London in 1882 and several important initiatic associations would see the light of day (*infra*, section II). In company with his friend Anthelme-Nizier Philippe (known as “Ma”tre Philippe of Lyons”), Papus went to Saint Petersburg to visit Nicholas II and the Tsarina on two occasions; he introduced them, they claim, to Martinism.

One of those that Papus called his spiritual masters was Joseph Alexandre Saint-Yves d'Alveydre, inventor toward 1900 of a “magical Archeometer” (a key revealing the correspondences among many domains of knowledge) and author of penetrating studies on musical esotericism. Also close to Papus by his purpose and by his work was Stanislas de Guaita (1861–1897; *Essais de Sciences maudites*; 1886; *Le Temple de Satan*, 1891; section II, I), one of the most famous authors of this current. Let us cite again Josephin Péladan (section III, 1, 3) in whom Occultism takes an artistic and literary form, as well as Charles Henry (1859–1926) and especially Albert Faucheux (*alias* François-Charles Barlet; *L'Occultisme*, 1909)—one of the principal figures, in France, of this same current. Paul Vulliaud was not an occultist, but the journal *Les Entretiens idéalistes* that he founded in 1906, and the artistic and literary movement that he motivated, are nevertheless part of this landscape.

Among the Russians appears in first place Piotr Dem'ianovich Ouspensky ([chapter 5](#), section II, 3), the author, notably, of *Tertium Organum* (Russian edition in 1912, English in 1920), which presents an interesting philosophy of Nature, considerations on the Tarot, dreams, etc. In Prague, several esoterically oriented centers were active around 1900. In the Netherlands, Occultism is represented notably by

Fredéric Van Eeden (*Het Hypnotisme en de Wonderen*, 1887), in Germany by Carl du Prel (*Studien aus dem Gebiete der Geheimwissenschaften*, 1894–1895) and especially Franz Hartmann (1838–1912; *Magic White and Black*, 1886; *Cosmology or Universal Science*, 1888; section III, 1, 2, 3). A discussion of certain representatives of this occultist current in England, including Aleister Crowley, follows *infra* and section III. Let us add finally that astrology experienced a new vogue in the years between 1880 and 1914; it occupied a prominent place in occultist literature and several specialized works (e.g., those of William Frederick Allan, *alias* Alan Leo, 1860–1917) attempt to confer greater credibility on it. After the publications already mentioned (section II, 1), which come within the extension of neo-Alexandrian Hermetism, let us cite a few of those of the occultist period properly speaking, also matched with very “hermeticizing” commentaries. They are the editions provided by the two famous “Rosicrucians” Hargrave Jennings and Pachal Beverly Randolph (section III, 1)—respectively in Madras in 1884 and in Toledo, Ohio, in 1889—and by Anna Bonus Kingsford (also author of several works, including *The Perfect Way* (1881; section III, 1, 2) and Edward Maitland, under the title *The Virgin of the World*, 1885. The most erudite of all, due to George Robert Stowe Mead (*Corpus Hermeticum*, 1906), would long be authoritative, even in academia.

In fact, unlike many commentators of the *CH* in his period, Mead is the author not only of many publications belonging to occultist thought (thus, *Quests New and Old*, 1913), but also of scholarly works pertaining to esoteric currents. It is the same for the works of another Englishman, Sir Arthur Edward Waite (1857–1942; section III, 1), a very important author whose works are resolutely in the line of the occultist movement of his period but that are not without scholarly merits (he wrote many works on the history of Freemasonry, Rosicrucianism, alchemy, Christian theosophy, etc.). William Wynn Westcott (section III, 1), another notable figure of this milieu in England, also strove—but with much less effectiveness and scope than Waite—to make known the riches of the Western esoteric currents of the past (thus, through his series *Collectanea Hermetica*, 1993–1902).

Between theosophers and occultists, the frontier is sometimes fluid, either because some of the latter (such as François-Charles Barlet; section II, 3) were also, in a certain manner, theosophers, or because they published earlier writings belonging to this current. Thus, Papus edited the letters of Martines de Pasqually and of Saint-Martin, and René Philipon, who signed as “Chevalier de la Rose Croissante,” provided in 1899 the very first edition of the *Traité de la Réintégration des Êtres* by this same Pasqually ([chapter 3](#), section I, 2). Nevertheless closer to this current was, for example, the Russian Vladimir Solovyov, Nature philosopher and sophiologist (in Russian: *Lectures on Theanthropy*, 1877–1881; *The Beauty of Nature*, 1889; *The Meaning of Love*, 1892–1894). We could not say that Rudolf Steiner (1861–1925), Nature philosopher and prolific author, is very closely connected with it.

Starting in his student years in Vienna, Steiner was concerned with natural sciences and physics, in the wake of Goethe, whose scientific works he co-edited (1883–1897). Thenceforth, he would never cease to meditate on the “esoteric” meaning of the teachings of the genius of Weimar (*Goethe als Theosoph*, 1904; his essays on Goethe's *Faust* and *Märchen* date from 1918). His production includes many essays, various treatises (*Theosophie*, 1904; *Die Geheimwissenschaft in Umriss*, 1910), innumerable lectures (most of them are published), and a few dramas (section III, 3).

In line with the Christocentric evolutionism that characterizes his thought, he insisted on the necessity of fully assuming the knowledge of the spiritual history of the West in view of its transmutation, and not relying on a Primordial Tradition from which we would passively expect manifestations in the form of new divine avatars. Therefore, the introduction, by the TS, of the young Krishnamurti as a Christ come back to earth caused Steiner to break away from this Society in 1913. Humanity on its journey must always, he held, work to find balance between two poles, the cosmic forces of expansion (opening of the being, aspiration toward the heights, but also egocentrism) and the forces of concentration (hardening, materialization). Reincarnation and “karma” play the role of instruments of liberation. To distinguish it firmly from the teachings of the TS, Steiner called his system “Anthroposophy,” and gave this name to the Society that he founded in 1913 (the Anthroposophical Society).

III. Esotericism in Initiatic Societies and in Art (1848–1914)

1. Masonic or Paramasonic Societies

In Masonry, it is especially (cf. [chapter 3](#), section I, 1) the Higher Grade Systems that draw inspiration from the esoteric currents. After the Revolution, the Rectified Scottish Rite continued in Switzerland; the Ancient and Accepted Scottish Rite remained alive, too—as well as a part of “Egyptian” Masonry, notably through the presence of the Rites of Memphis and of Mishraim. At the end of the nineteenth century, we can observe the same phenomenon as about a hundred years earlier—namely, the creation and the proliferation of new Societies of this type.

In 1868, Paschal Beverly Randolph (1825–1875; section II, 3) founded the most ancient Rosicrucian group in the United States, the *Fraternitas Rosae Crucis*. Thereafter, in 1876, the Swedenborgian Rite known as the Illuminated Theosophists ([chapter 3](#), section III, 2) returned from America to Europe. Of a distinctly Christian orientation, the *Societas Rosicruciana in Anglia* (SRIA), branching from regular English Freemasonry, includes Higher Grades inspired by those of the Gold- und Rosenkreuzer of the eighteenth century ([chapter 3](#), section III, 2). Born in London in 1867, it is the creation of learned occultists such as Robert Wentworth Little (1840–1918) and Kenneth R. H. Mackenzie (1833–1886).

Bulwer-Lytton (section I, 1; section II, 2) and Éliphas Lévi were honorary members; William Wynn Westcott (section II, 3) was its Supremus Magus from 1891 to 1925.

The year 1888 saw the birth in France of a Rose-Croix Kabbalistique, founded by Guaita (section II, 2) and Péladan (section III, 3), which would go through many fragmentations and estrangements. The year 1891 saw the birth of the Martinist Order, a creation of Papus (the adjective refers to the names Martines de Pasqually and Louis-Claude de Saint-Martin), which, from its incipience, has always accepted women as members. We have seen (section II, 3) that Nicolas II—open to the “occult” as were the last Romanovs—would have been a member. The year 1888 saw the emergence of the Fraternitas (a creation of Franz Hartmann (section II, 3; section III, 2, 3) in Germany, and of the Order of the Golden Dawn (GD) in England, which also accepted women (it was an outgrowth of the SRIA). Created by Westcott (cf. *supra*), William Robert Woodman and Samuel Liddell MacGregor Mathers, the GD drew inspiration from the Kabbalah as well as the Tarot; it gave an important place to ceremonial magic (which is not the case of the SRIA).

An English translation, by Samuel L. MacGregor Mathers, of *The Book of the Sacred Magic of Abramelin the Mage* (a theurgic ritual in Latin, from an old manuscript of uncertain provenance and period) was published in 1898, and then circulated in the form of a Rite known to the members of the GD. The celebrated writer William Butler Yeats, who was initiated into the GD in 1888, directed it for several months. Aleister Crowley (1875–1947; [chapter 5](#), section I, 1; section III, 1)—probably the most famous figure of the whole occultist movement in England—after joining in 1898, remained a member for only eighteen months. Waite (section II, 3) was a member starting in 1891. The Stella Matutina created in 1903 is a branch of it. Between 1906 and 1910, the occultist Theodor Reuss established the Ordo Templi Orientis (OTO), a Lodge for research in secret sciences whose destiny was also directed by Aleister Crowley. The latter further organized its rituals, endowing them with a more pronounced sexual and anti-Christian aspect. He created in parallel, in 1909, an Astrum Argentinum that is founded on the teachings of the GD. Rudolf Steiner, who probably was never a member of the OTO, created his own Anthroposophical Society in Dornach, near Basel (section II, 3), which is not of a masonic type. Another important organization is the Rosicrucian Fellowship, creation of Carl Louis von Grasshoff (*alias* Max Heindel) in 1907 and whose world center is located in Oceanside, California.

There existed other circles, associations, and movements. Thus, the Mouvement Cosmique, founded around 1900 by Max Théon—continuation of the Hermetic Brotherhood of Luxor—produced starting in 1903 an enormous body of work entitled *Tradition cosmique*, dedicated to the “original tradition.” Some of these movements assembled Christians; this is the case for the Hermetic Academy of Anna Bonus Kingsford (section II, 3; section III, 2). In France, Yvon Le Loup (*alias* Paul Sédir, 1871–1926),

collaborator of Papus, led the group known as *Les Amitiés Spirituelles*. The Jesuit Victor Drevon and Alexis de Sarachaga created in 1873 a center of esoteric studies at Parayle-Monial, the Hieron. This list is partial; it does not include many groupings and associations that exceed the limits of our purpose, as for example the Gnostic Church founded in 1890 by Jules Doinel.

2. The Theosophical Society

Founded in 1875 in New York by Helena Petrovna Blavatsky (“H. P.B.,” 1831–1891; section II, 1), Henry Steel Olcott and William Quan Judge, the TS—which is not masonic in character—went through various forms and ramifications in the course of its history but that have preserved the same common denominators. “Theosophism,” a generic term used to describe its orientation, does not set forth a “doctrine” properly speaking, although the title of the book of H.P.B., *The Secret Doctrine* (1888; preceded by *Isis Unveiled*, 1877) customarily serves as a reference for the theosophists (in English, this term distinguishes them from the theosophers of the “classical” Christian theosophical current). At its foundation in 1875, the TS fixed a triple goal for itself, respected by the branches issued from it. These were, first, to form the nucleus of a universal fellowship; second, to encourage the study of all the religions, of philosophy, and of science; and third, to study the laws of Nature as well as the psychical and spiritual powers of the human being. By its content and its inspiration, it is largely dependent on Eastern spiritualities, especially Hindu; in this, it well reflects the cultural climate in which it was born. H.P.B. and her Society never tired of affirming the unity of all the religions in their “esoteric” foundations, and of trying to develop, among those people who had the desire for it, the faculty of becoming “true theosophists.” In its beginnings especially, the TS devoted a good share of its activities to the “psychical” or “metaphysical,” areas that were objects of vivid interest at the time. Departed for India in 1878, H.P.B. founded there in 1879 her journal *The Theosophist* and established, there too, in 1883 (at Adyar, near Madras, India) the official seat of her Society. The latter was well accepted by the natives of the country, more especially in view of the climate of tolerance that reigned within this movement. H.P.B. returned to Europe in 1885.

The history of the branches of the TS after the death of its founder in 1891 is rich and complex; let us mention notably the creation in 1909, by Robert Crosbie, of the United Lodge of Theosophists. Three factors favored the influence of this movement, implanted in most Western countries.

The first is the presence of significant personalities, such as Annie Besant (1847–1933), its president starting in 1907, Franz Hartmann (founder of a German branch in 1886; section II, 3; III, 1, 2), and Rudolf Steiner (general secretary of the German section in 1902). Steiner broke away from the TS in 1913 ([chapter 4](#), section III, 2), of which the inclination for Eastern traditions seemed to him

irreconcilable with the Christian and Western character of his own orientation. Before him and for this same reason, Anna Bonus Kingsford, an influential figure of a feminine and Christian Occultism in the years 1870 and 1880 (section II, 3; section III, 1), broke away from it to establish a Hermetic Society penetrated by Christianity. However, in creating their own organizations, personalities like Steiner, and to a lesser degree Anna Kingsford, contributed to spread, even in a modified form, teachings issued from their mother Society.

The second factor comprises the many links that the various branches have maintained with most of the other Societies of this type. Thus, the international Spiritist and Spiritualist Congress of 1889 and the Masonic and Spiritualist Congress of 1908, which met in Paris, represent a good example of this crossroads of ideas and of tendencies. Moreover, the frontiers differentiating most of these movements from one another were rather permeable; it is instead inside each one of them that oppositions were enacted, that people fulminated “excommunications.”

The third factor, finally, is obviously the great number of artists having manifestly undergone the influence of the TS—a point that is the subject of part of the following section.

3. Esoteric Arts and Literature

Among the great French writers that drew from the referential corpus of the esoteric currents appears Gérard de Nerval (*Voyage en Orient*, 1851; *Les Illuminés*, 1852; *Les Chimères*, 1854). The sonnet by Charles Baudelaire (“Correspondances,” around 1857) has become a sort of poetic *Emerald Tablet*, and the texts of this author on the notion of creative imagination are not without affinities with what is one of the components of the esoteric “form of thought” (cf. introduction, section IV). The thematic range in *Contemplations* (1856) of Victor Hugo is close to that of the most classical Christian theosophy (let us also recall that between 1853 and 1855, in Jersey and in Guernsey, Hugo the spiritualist conversed with Dante and Shakespeare). In Villiers de L'Isle-Adam, Occultism found one of its best authors of fiction (*Isis*, 1862; *Axël*, 1888); it is also present in Saint-Pol-Roux (*Les Reposeurs de la Procession*, 1893), and for Josephin Péladan (section II, 3; section III, 1) it inspired an impressive saga (*L'Éthopée*, 1886–1907). In Paris, the exhibitions of the Salons de la Rose-Croix, connected with the Order founded by Péladan (section II, 3), are one of the most aesthetically fertile episodes in the occultist current; from 1893 to 1898, one could admire there the works of Félicien Rops; Georges Rouault and Erik Satie took part in it. In the same period, a few works of “Rosicrucian” fiction also appeared in the wake of Bulwer-Lytton's *Zanoni* (section I, 5). Examples are the novel by Franz Hartmann, *An Adventure among the Rosicrucians*

(1887; section II, 3; section III, 1, 2) and one by Emma Hardinge Britten, *Ghostland, or Researches into the Mysteries of Occultism* (1876)—one of the principal works of fiction inspired by the occultist current and animal magnetism.

The musical production work of Richard Wagner, from 1843 to 1882, incarnated for the Belle Époque the idea of music elevated to the rank of religion. Both his texts and scores remain a privileged place of hermeneutics. However, the existence of any “esotericism” in his work is mostly in the minds of certain readers and listeners. This remark would also apply to the reception of the work of painters such as Arnold Böcklin or Gustave Moreau. Like Wagner in Bayreuth, Rudolf Steiner created at Dornach (near Basel), the seat of his Anthroposophical Society, a *Gesamtkunstwerk* (a “total artistic work” like Wagner's project, of a very Germanic nature). It was the “Goethanum” ([chapter 5](#), section III, 1), a building meant to reflect the very spirit of the Society and to be a site appropriate for the performance of dramas (principally of those that he authored: *Die Pforte der Einweihung*, 1910; *Die Prüfung der Seele*, 1911; *Der Hüter der Schwelle*, 1912; *Der Seelen Erwachen*, 1913).